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LIFE AND WORKS OF RIZAL

Reflection Paper on Finding Rizal in a time of Barriers by Loren Legarda

Watching the documentary, it is very endearing to see a more human side of Jose Rizal outside of seeing his usual image of greatness along with the weight of what he did for our country. Seeing Rizal's relationship with the pastor and the letters and writings he exchanged during his stay, Legarda rethinks Rizal by showing him as a human being who struggled with discrimination, poverty, homesickness, and political oppression, yet still pursued knowledge and used his talents to fight for the dignity of Filipinos.

Being able to see during Rizal's stay, he managed to form a meaningful relationship and wonderful bonds with the people abroad despite being a foreigner (He quoted ". You understood me too, in spite of my brown skin.") during a time where racial and social barriers were very very visible. The way the Ullmer family continued to preserve Rizal's letter for generations shows how they deeply value him and shows his impact to the people around him. It surprised me how much Rizal is being valued even outside the country, which is very sweet.

It is a beautiful part for me is where Rizal started appreciating the Filipino culture more while being abroad. Being exposed to the other cultures in Europe helped him recognize his value with his identity as a Filipino. Rizal's experiences show that understanding one's identity sometimes becomes clearer through distance and reflection. There are moments in my life where I took pride with my identity when I am interacting with my foreign friends and hearing their opinions.

The documentary changed the way I view Rizal. Before, I mostly saw him as a national hero written in textbooks and remembered during holidays. This documentary made me see a very new side and a more human story since we witnessed how he is outside of the greatness he had. Records of his written humor, his relationships, and his struggles showed me a person who struggled, learned, and grew through his experiences. Rizal's journey reminds us that barriers will always exist, but they should not stop us from continuing to learn, improve ourselves, and contribute to society.